



Journalism 1

OPTIMA ACADEMY ONLINE · FAMILY COURSE OVERVIEW · GRADES 9–12 · FULL YEAR · 1 CREDIT · ELECTIVE

~4¼ hrs per week · 50 min/day, M–F

About this overview. This document is an example of how the course might be taught. This page is drawn from the official course descriptions rather than a built Optima course, so the specific units, stories, and activities scholars see will be set by the teacher and may vary between the live school and On-Demand. Each teacher also leans into their own strengths and passions; the structure, expectations, and time commitment below are representative of the course as designed.

Journalism 1 invites scholars to learn how news is gathered, verified, and communicated with clarity. Scholars develop entry-level skills in telling stories and packaging them across print, multimedia, web, and broadcast platforms, while practicing the virtues of the craft: accuracy, fairness, the pursuit of truth, and responsibility to readers. The course covers journalism's history and ethics, layout and production, and the many forms of journalistic writing — news, feature, sports, and editorial. Scholars engage real news sources and contemporary journalistic work through digital platforms and AI-assisted research tools. The course assumes journalism is a serious craft serving a serious purpose: helping citizens understand their world and each other.

THE YEAR AT A GLANCE

1 What Journalism Is (foundation)

The history of journalism, its ethics, and the responsible use of information — including photojournalism.

3 Reporting and Research (all year)

Interviewing, verifying, and researching with reliable sources — the discipline of getting it right.

5 Publishing (all year)

Collaborative platforms and editing tools that carry writing from draft to publication-ready work.

2 Journalistic Writing (all year)

News, feature, sports, and editorial writing, each crafted for its audience, purpose, and context.

4 Production Across Platforms (all year)

Packaging stories for print, web, multimedia, and broadcast, with fundamental layout and design skills.

6 Careers in Journalism (woven through)

The varied careers across the formats of 21st-century journalism.

A TYPICAL WEEK

- Reading and analyzing real journalism most days: how working reporters structure stories and earn trust.
- Regular writing across the journalistic forms, drafted, edited, and revised toward publication quality.
- Reporting practice: research, interviews, and verification with credible sources.
- Production work that packages stories for different platforms.

TIME COMMITMENT

250 minutes / week

≈ 50 minutes a day, Monday–Friday

- Reading, writing, and production work fill most of the scheduled time.
- Story deadlines and production weeks may run longer — as in a real newsroom.

WHAT SCHOLARS NEED

- A computer with reliable internet and access to Canvas.
- A reporter's notebook for interviews, observations, and story ideas.
- Microsoft 365 and OneDrive (provided to every scholar) for drafting and publishing work.

On-Demand (asynchronous). Scholars move through the course at their own pace, with due dates to keep the year on track. An Optima teacher is available throughout for support, feedback, and grading.

Live school. Live-school scholars take this same course on Optima's VR campus with a teacher and classmates, when offered live; for 2026–27 Journalism is listed as an On-Demand course.